

cqcpack: An R Package for Accessing Care Quality Commission Data

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Background

The Care Quality Commission (CQC)

- Independent regulator of health and social care services in England
- As of 22 April 2026, has published inspection ratings of 120,996 registered locations and 63,517 registered providers
- Their ratings are widely regarded as the standard for assessing care quality though there is active research in challenging/improving the metric
- Consulted by service users, local authorities, commissioners, and researchers

The Problem

- CQC data is available via a public API but **does not support bulk downloads**
- Retrieving all records manually can take **days**
- CQC updates their records daily, which makes getting **up to date** records tedious

The CQC Syndication API



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Syndication

Search operations

API definition Changelog

Group by tag

GET Get Changes Within Timeframe

GET Get Inspection Areas

GET Get Location AssessmentServiceGro...

GET Get Location By Id

GET Get Location Inspection Areas

GET Get Locations

GET Get Provider By Id

GET Get Provider Inspection Areas By Loc...

GET Get Provider Inspection Areas By Pro...

GET Get Provider Locations

GET Get Providers

GET Get Providers AssessmentServiceGro...

Syndication

CQC Syndication API provides details about the services and data accessible through this API, along with information that will show you how to begin integration with your platform. CQC Syndication is a collection of REST APIs that exposes the ability for customers and providers to provider interactions into CQC's systems and processes.

Get Location By Id

The Get Location by id endpoint allows consumers to get the location assessment details for given location id

LocationOrganization DetailsSyndication

Request

GET <https://api.service.cqc.org.uk/public/v1/locations/{id}>

Request parameters

Name	In	Required	Type	Description
id	template	true	string	The organisation Id of the location.

<https://api-portal.service.cqc.org.uk/>

What is cqcpack?

cqcpack provides an **automated pipeline** for accessing CQC data in bulk from the publicly accessible Syndication API.

It solves four problems:

- 1 Automating API calls
- 2 Caching JSON responses
- 3 Parsing JSONs into datasets
- 4 Incrementally updating changes

Output

- Location dataset - location_df.rda
- Provider dataset - provider_df.rda
- Merged dataset - merged_df.rda

How It Works

Pipeline

Scrape IDs → Download JSONs → Parse into tibbles → Build & Merge

Incremental Updates

- GitHub Actions runs the updates ever night
- Queries the CQC /changes endpoint to fetch only updated records
- Historical JSON snapshots archived in `cqc-data-repo` for reproducibility

Using the Package

Installation

```
# Install from GitHub
```

```
remotes::install_github("Care-Policy-and-Evaluation-Centre/cqcpack")  
library(cqcpack)
```

Look up by ID

```
# For a location ID
```

```
location_info <- get_cqc_id_info("1-10000302982", id_type = "location")
```

```
# For a provider ID
```

```
provider_info <- get_cqc_id_info("1-102642938", id_type = "provider")
```

For more usages checkout

<https://care-policy-and-evaluation-centre.github.io/cqcpack/introduction.html>

Who benefits?

- **Researchers** - analyse care quality trends and policy impact across England
- **NHS commissioners** - monitor provider quality within their area
- **Local authorities** - track care home and community service standards
- **Policy analysts** - build longitudinal datasets linking ratings to regulatory interventions

Summary of First Release

- `cqcpack` provides the first dedicated R interface to the CQC Syndication API
- Automates the process from ID scraping to creating datasets that are ready to be analysed
- Daily automated updates and a historical archive to ensure data is always current and reproducible
- Functions allow users to query individual ID information without any API knowledge
- Facilitates research into care quality, service accessibility, and health policy across England

Limitation

- Historical and longitudinal data are not readily accessible
- JSON archives: Records of locations and providers with detected changes are stored as JSON files in cq-c-data-repo
- Commit history: Older snapshots can be retrieved from the cqcpack commit history via previous .rda files

In Development

- Introduction of a dedicated function for building custom historical datasets.
- Users will be able to specify a time span and select variables of interest.
- Scope: systematically track and map providers and locations that have been updated, reassigned, or closed over time.

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Archived package: <https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.19005826>